LEFLUNOMIDE

Teratogenic — washout needed

Hepatotoxic

CHEMICAL NAME 5-methyl-N-[4-(trifluoromethyl)phenyl]isoxazole-4-carboxamide
CLASS Pyrimidine synthesis inhibitor (DMARD)
TRADE NAMES Arava · Leflunomide (generic) · Lefno

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Rheumatoid arthritis (alternative or adjunct to methotrexate).
- Psoriatic arthritis.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** once daily with or without food.
- Loading dose often omitted (GI upset).

DOSAGES

- **Maintenance:** 10–20 mg once daily.
- Loading (optional): 100 mg daily for 3 days.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 4–6 weeks.
- Prodrug → active teriflunomide (enterohepatic recirculation).
- **t½:** ~2 weeks; detectable for up to 2 years without washout.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Inhibits **dihydroorotate dehydrogenase** → ↓ pyrimidine synthesis → inhibits proliferation of activated T lymphocytes.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Diarrhoea, nausea, abdominal pain.
- Hair loss, rash.
- Hypertension, weight loss.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Hepatotoxicity (severe, sometimes fatal).
- Bone-marrow suppression; serious infections.
- Interstitial lung disease; peripheral neuropathy.
- SJS/TEN; teratogenicity.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Pregnancy (and women not using reliable contraception); breastfeeding.
- Hepatic impairment; severe immunodeficiency; serious infection.
- Moderate–severe renal impairment; significant bone-marrow dysfunction.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Methotrexate, other hepatotoxic drugs:** ↑ hepatotoxicity.
- **Live vaccines:** avoid.
- **Cholestyramine, activated charcoal:** ↓ levels (used for washout).
- **Warfarin:** ↑ INR.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Baseline BP, weight, FBC, LFTs; repeat FBC/LFT every 2 weeks for 6 months, then every 8 weeks.
- Monitor BP at every visit.
- Pregnancy planning requires washout (cholestyramine 8 g TDS for 11 days) and level checks.
- Assess for infection.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Use reliable contraception; men and women planning conception need washout.
- Report yellow skin, dark urine, rash, sore throat, breathlessness.
- Limit alcohol.
- Have BP checked regularly.

KEY POINTS

- DHODH inhibitor DMARD.
- Hepatotoxic; hypertension; diarrhoea.
- 10–20 mg daily.
- Teratogenic — long t½, washout with cholestyramine.

SOURCES CHECKED **[846]** Leflunomide 10 mg Film-coated Tablets (UK SmPC) **[847]** Leflunomide, oral (US label) **[848]** Leflunomide, oral (US label, KVK-Tech)

Full references p. 432–457